he might surrender.

When the envoy arrived, Kamran was the very picture of submission. ‘I’ve sinned, I’ve sinned,’ he said, head bowed. ‘I’ll do whatever you order.’

The stage was set for a grand reconciliation. The defecting chieftains appeared before Humayun, one by one, swords hanging from their necks. ‘What ailed *you*, and what made *you* go away?’ asked Humayun of one of whom he’d expected better. But the question was rhetorical. Humayun knew what had happened: ‘’Tis the fortune of war, such accidents as this must happen.’ A few days later came Kamran’s turn. The rebel prince humbled himself before his brother, making all the requisite salutes and prostrations. Then, Humayun pulled him into a hug: ‘Now come and let us embrace like brothers.’ With Kamran firmly in his grip, Humayun burst into tears.[45] Such tendency to weep has given Humayun his reputation for sentimentality, though it might be that he wept as much to wash away his own sins as those of his brother.

Both had a chance to redeem themselves now. Not just Humayun and Kamran, but all Babur’s sons – and their cousin Sulaiman – were together, seated on the same carpet, eating off the same cloth. They were even to wash their hands in the same basin. The protocol of age decreed that Humayun went first, followed by Kamran, then Sulaiman, Askari and Hindal. Sulaiman of Badakhshan, unused perhaps to the courtly ways of Kabul and Agra, took to the hand-washing with more aplomb than decorum, possibly he blew his nose. At this, the younger brothers exploded in protest against such ‘nose-wagging performances’, crying, ‘What rusticity is this?’[46]

Poor, abashed Sulaiman may have cheered up as the celebration progressed: the bright, vibrating sounds of harp, rebec and qopuz filled the air, men sang and ate and talked until the sun set. So convivial was the atmosphere that, the next day, the Timurid men even plotted a joint campaign against Balkh.

The what-ifs of history are tempting detours. What if, now, the brothers had attacked Balkh?[47] On the borders of Turan and only 500-odd kilometres south of Samarqand, Balkh would have been a launching pad into Timur’s great capital; its conquest might have shaped a wholly different destiny for his descendants. When they parted, at Taligan, the brothers and Sulaiman